

THE MOTOWN UNIVERSE

Executive Development Memo #013 — Phase 1, Film 4: Lead, Release Date & Full Film Sheet

CONFIDENTIAL • An alternate-reality “what if” • Fidelity Rating: 100% • Nerf Tolerance: 0%

WHAT'S GOING ON

LEAD: Marvin Gaye • RELEASE: Friday, May 4, 2012

Phase 1, Film 4 • The Thor role • Motown Productions / Paramount • PG-13 • approx. 150 min

A. Why Marvin Gaye

Thor is a proud prince who must lose everything, get sent down to earth, and become worthy of his own power. Marvin Gaye was known as the “**Prince of Motown**” and lived that arc for real. He was also married to Berry Gordy's sister Anna, which made him part of the royal family. *Hitsville 2*'s post-credits scene already set him up (Memo #012).

Thor	Marvin Gaye (documented history)
A prince of the realm	The “Prince of Motown,” married to Anna Gordy
Odin, the king he must answer to	Berry Gordy, head of Motown and his brother-in-law. Also his real father, Rev. Marvin Gay Sr., a strict and harsh minister
Arrogant, wants glory his own way	Wanted to be a Nat King Cole-style crooner and resisted Motown's R&B hit formula
Jane Foster, the partner who changes him	Tammi Terrell, his duet partner. A creative partnership, not a romance
Banished to Earth, powerless	After Tammi's death he stopped performing and tried out for the Detroit Lions football team (1970)
Becomes worthy and lifts the hammer	Finds his own voice and makes <i>What's Going On</i> (1971)

B. Release Date: Friday, May 4, 2012

Thor opened on the first Friday in May 2011. The TMU runs one year behind the MCU, so *What's Going On* takes the first Friday in May 2012: May 4, 2012. It opens the 2012 summer, one year after *Hitsville 2*.

C. Full Film Sheet (Memo #008)

1. Title: *What's Going On*

This is the title of Marvin's 1971 masterpiece and the song he fought Motown to release. It's the moment he becomes worthy. To the public, it's a song title (Memo #007).

2. What's Being Adapted

Source	Used for
Primary: David Ritz, <i>Divided Soul: The Life of Marvin Gaye</i> (1985)	Marvin's inner life, his father, and the fight over <i>What's Going On</i>
Frankie Gaye with Fred E. Basten, <i>Marvin Gaye, My Brother</i> (2003)	The brothers' bond and Frankie's Vietnam experience
The master recordings, label credits, and the Billboard chart record	Every song, credit and chart position on screen

3. What the Movie Is About

Logline: Motown's prince wants to be a crooner, becomes a hitmaker, loses his partner, gets knocked off his throne, and wins it back by making the album the king said would never sell.

Act One: The Prince (1961–1966). Marvin plays drums on sessions and dreams of singing standards. He marries Anna Gordy and gives in to the R&B formula. The hits come anyway: “Stubborn Kind of Fellow,” “Pride and Joy” and “How Sweet It Is (To Be Loved by You).”

Act Two: The Fall (1967–1970). His duets with Tammi Terrell, including “Ain't No Mountain High Enough,” make them Motown's greatest pairing. In October 1967 she collapses into his arms on stage. “I Heard It Through the Grapevine” becomes a #1 hit (1968–69), but his triumph is empty. Tammi dies in March 1970. Marvin stops performing and tries out for the Detroit Lions.

Act Three: Worthy (1970–1971). His brother Frankie comes home from Vietnam with stories of war. Renaldo “Obie” Benson of the Four Tops brings him a song. Marvin produces it himself. Gordy refuses to release it, and Marvin refuses to record anything else. The single “What's Going On” comes out in January 1971 and becomes a smash. The album *What's Going On* (May 1971) makes him an artist in full control of his own work.

4. Whose Movie / Franchise It Is

Marvin Gaye's. He's shown at full strength (No-Nerf): the voice, the vision, the pride and the pain, all as documented.

5. Antagonist

Level	Antagonist	What the record supports
Primary	The Motown hit formula, and Gordy's refusal to release <i>What's Going On</i>	The throne that stands between the prince and his own voice. Gordy is shown as documented: a brilliant businessman who was, this time, wrong.
Human	Rev. Marvin Gay Sr.	The harsh father whose shadow Marvin carries. It's shown through documented flashbacks only.
Internal	Grief and self-doubt	Tammi's death and his withdrawal from the stage.

6. Timeline: When & Where

	Setting
When	1961 to May 1971, with flashbacks to his childhood in Washington, D.C. The fixed points are Tammi's collapse (Oct. 1967), "Grapevine" at #1 (late 1968), Tammi's death (Mar. 1970), and the single (Jan. 1971) and album (May 1971).
Where	Detroit (Hitsville and Studio A); Washington, D.C.; Hampden-Sydney College, Virginia (the 1967 collapse); and the Detroit Lions tryout (1970).
Master timeline	TMU Chapter Four. It overlaps Chapters Two and Three and runs past both, making it the latest-set Phase 1 film.

7. Standalone World-Building

Marvin's world stands on its own: his D.C. childhood and his father, his marriage into the Gordy family, his partnership with Tammi, his brother Frankie, and the social turmoil of the late 1960s. It's a complete story from prince to fall to worthiness (40% serialized / 60% standalone).

8. Motown Universe World-Building

Type	Established in What's Going On
Returning	Gordy, Anna Gordy, Smokey, the Hitsville sets, Quality Control, and the actor who played Marvin in <i>Hitsville</i> and <i>Hitsville 2</i> .
New characters	Tammi Terrell, Frankie Gaye, Rev. Marvin Gay Sr., Renaldo "Obie" Benson and the Four Tops, and Harvey Fuqua.
Crossover scene	The "Please Mr. Postman" session (1961), seen from Marvin's side behind the drum kit. It matches the post-credits scene of <i>Hitsville 2</i> exactly.
Plot elements	The artist-versus-Motown fight for creative control, a thread every later film will build on.

9. Post-Credits Scene: One

Scene	Setting	What happens
End-credits	Birmingham, Alabama, 1962	Workers stretch a rope down the middle of an auditorium floor to split the audience by race, as posters for the Motortown Revue go up outside. Rope-divided audiences were standard on the Southern circuit, as tour members have described. This is the TMU's version of <i>Thor's</i> Tesseract scene: it sets up the threat the team will face.

10. How It Kicks Everything Off

N/A. This field is for the first film only (Memo #008).

Compliance Check

Mandate	Status
Fidelity (Memo #001)	PASS. Every event, song, credit and date comes from the documented record.
No-Nerf (Memo #001)	PASS. Every character appears at full documented strength.
Studio (Memos #002–#003)	PASS. Motown Productions, distributed by Paramount.
Phase (Memo #004)	PASS. Phase 1, Film 4 of 6. Released May 4, 2012.
Story model (Memo #005)	PASS. 40% serialized / 60% standalone.
Format (Memo #005)	PASS. Musical Biographical Drama, PG-13, approx. 150 min.
Continuity (Memo #005)	PASS. The same actor plays Marvin as in Films 1 and 3, the “Postman” scene matches, and the dates fit the master timeline.
Secrecy (Memo #007)	PASS. Publicly marketed as a Marvin Gaye biopic, with no universe branding.

TMU is a fan-made alternate-reality concept. It has no connection to Motown Records, Universal, Paramount or Marvel Studios. The people named are real. The films and the roles here are fictional.